

11 Slovakia

Gradual Settlement of Rules in an Unstable Environment

Branislav Dolný

The institutional setting

During the observation period from 2008, the basic institutional framework and balance of power have been stable. Slovakia is a parliamentary democracy with a unicameral parliament elected by a proportional electoral system in a single district for a period of four years, with a directly elected president for a period of five years. The electoral system has a significant degree of proportionality. Apart from the 5 per cent threshold,¹ it does not favour large parties; therefore, it is conducive to a greater number of parties in parliament (which was never less than six). This usually results in multi-party government coalitions as shown in the [Table 11.1a](#).

Although directly elected, the president has limited competencies, he or she can still be an important player in government formation. After the election or dismissal of the government, he or she will appoint the formateur with the task of forming a government. The Constitution does not limit the president in any way in the choice. In practice, however, presidents follow the unwritten rule of appointing the leader (or representative) of the largest parliamentary party as a formateur after the election. If the formateur finds an agreement with majority support for his government in parliament, the president appoints him or her as prime minister and, on the PM proposal, appoints the members of the cabinet. The new government is then obliged to submit its programme statement to parliament within 30 days and win the support of majority of MPs.

According to Constitution, parliament has the opportunity to express a vote of no confidence in the government or its individual members at any time, and the president has to dismiss the cabinet or the individual minister. Likewise, the president dismisses a member of the government on the proposal of its prime minister. However, the Constitution does not make it clear whether the president is obliged to appoint and remove a member of the government on the proposal of the prime minister. Although a 1999 amendment to the Constitution was intended to oblige the president to respect the prime minister's proposals, the legal interpretation of this article is still ambiguous (Balog and Trellová 2010). The powers of the president towards the government were strengthened by a major amendment to the

Table 11.1a Slovakian cabinets 1992–2021

<i>Cabinet number</i>	<i>Cabinet</i>	<i>Date in</i>	<i>Election date</i>	<i>Party composition of cabinet</i>	<i>Type of cabinet</i>	<i>Cabinet strength in seats (%)</i>	<i>Number of seats in parliament</i>	<i>Number of parties in parliament</i>	<i>ENP, parliament</i>	<i>Formal support parties</i>
1	Mečiar I	1992-06-24	1992-06-06	ĽS-HZDS, SNS	mwc	89 (59.3)	150	5	3.19	SDL
2	Mečiar II	1993-03-19		ĽS-HZDS	min	74 (49.3)	150	5	3.19	
3	Mečiar III	1993-11-10		ĽS-HZDS, SNS	mwc	89 (59.3)	150	5	3.19	
4	Moravčík	1994-03-16		DUS, SDL, KDH	min	74 (49.3)	150	6	4.68	
5	Mečiar IV	1994-12-13	1994-10-01	ĽS-HZDS, ZRS, SNS	mwc	83 (55.3)	150	7	4.41	Independent MPs who left ANO
6	Dzurinda I	1998-10-30	1998-09-26	SDK, SDL, SMK, SOP	sur	93 (62)	150	6	4.75	
7	Dzurinda II	2002-10-16	2002-09-22	SDKU-DS, SMK, KDH, ANO	mwc	78 (52)	150	7	6.12	
8	Dzurinda III	2005-09-01		SDKU-DS, SMK, KDH	min	63 (42)	150	7	6.31	
9	Dzurinda IV	2006-02-08		SDKU-DS, SMK	min	48 (32)	150	7	6.31	Independent MPs who left ANO
10	Fico I	2006-07-04	2006-06-17	Smer-SD, SNS, ĽS-HZDS	mwc	85 (56.7)	150	6	4.81	
11	Radičová	2010-07-09	2010-06-12	SDKU-DS, SaS, KDH, MH	mwc	79 (52.7)	150	6	4.01	
12	Fico II	2012-04-04	2012-03-10	Smer-SD	maj	83 (55.3)	150	6	2.88	
13	Fico III	2016-03-23	2016-03-05	Smer-SD, SNS, MH, Siet'	mwc	81 (54)	150	8	5.75	
14	Fico IV	2016-08-31		Smer-SD, SNS, MH	mwc	81 (54)	150	8	5.67	
15	Pellegrini	2018-03-22	2016-03-05	Smer-SD, SNS, MH	mwc	78 (52)	150	7	5.71	
16	Matovič	2020-03-21	2020-02-29	OĽaNO, SR, SaS, ZL	sur	95 (63.3)	150	6	4.37	
17	Heger	2021-04-01		OĽaNO, SR, SaS, ZL	sur	93 (62)	150	9	5.25	

Notes:

For a list of parties, consult the chapter appendix.

The number of parties in parliament does not include parties that have never held more than two seats when a cabinet has been formed.

Cabinet types: min = minority cabinet (both single-party and coalition cabinets); maj = single-party majority cabinet; mwc = minimal-winning coalition; sur = surplus majority coalition.

Constitution approved by the parliament in 2011. This amendment says that a caretaker government may exercise some of its powers only with the prior consent of the president.

So far, the presidents have always respected that the formation of the government is a matter for the negotiations among the parliamentary parties. Nevertheless, this is an informal rule. Since 2008, the president has used the opportunity to influence the composition of the government only once. In 2018, the president made the appointment of the prime minister and the government conditional on changing the nominee to the Minister of the Interior, which was accepted by the coalition. It cannot be completely ruled out that a more activist president could become an important player in the formation of the government and the governing coalition in the future.

The Constitution provides limited possibilities for the president to call early elections. It should be done only under exceptional circumstances such as the inaction of parliament or a failed referendum on the removal of the president. In previous practice, early elections were held by approval of the constitutional law by the parliament but a decision² of the Constitutional Court in 2021 declared this procedure unconstitutional.

The party system and the actors

After a period in the 1990s which was marked by the authoritarian style of Prime Minister Mečiar, which made national identity and democracy the basis of party competition, in the new millennium, as indicated in Table 11.1b, the left-right divide increasingly became the dominant dimension with two blocs of parties alternating in government (Szomolányi and Karvai 2019). The first two terms after 2008 confirmed this division even though an imbalance was evident. Direction-Social Democracy (Smer-SD) was the dominant force of the left and it was able to integrate most of the left-wing parties (including

Table 11.1b Slovakian system conflict structure 2006–2021

<i>Cabinet number</i>	<i>Cabinet</i>	<i>Median party in the first dimension</i>	<i>First dimension conflict</i>	<i>Median party in the second dimension</i>	<i>Second dimension conflict</i>
10	Fico I	ĽS-HZDS	Econ. left-right	Smer-SD	
11	Radičová	MH	Econ. left-right	Smer-SD	
12	Fico II	Smer-SD	Econ. left-right	Smer-SD	
13	Fico III	LSNS	Econ. left-right	Smer-SD	GAL-TAN
14	Fico IV	LSNS	Econ. left-right	Smer-SD	GAL-TAN
15	Pellegrini	LSNS	Econ. left-right	Smer-SD	GAL-TAN
16	Matovič	OĽaNO	Econ. left-right	OĽaNO	GAL-TAN
17	Heger	OĽaNO	Econ. left-right	OĽaNO	GAL-TAN

Notes: Median parties for the period 2006–2012 (cabinets 10–12) retrieved from Bergman et al (2019).

the communist successor party, which lost relevance after 2002) as well as a large part of Vladimir Mečiar's former supporters. The right remained fragmented with frequent reconfigurations and mergers. The right-wing parties differed mainly in their attitudes to cultural issues – cultural conservatism was represented by Christian Democratic Movement (KDH), a more moderate approach by Slovak Democratic and Christian Union-Democratic Party (SDKÚ-DS), cultural liberalism by Freedom and Solidarity (SaS) and Bridge (MH) representing Hungarian minority.

The early termination of the right-wing coalition in 2012 resulted in sweeping victory for Smer-SD, which for the first time since the fall of communism was able to form a one-party majority government (Malová and Dolný 2016). Despite the right-wing parties weakening at the polls, they all returned to parliament and further confirmed the dominance of the L/R dimension and the consolidation of the party system. The only new party was Common People and Independent Personalities (OĽaNO), led by an eccentric businessman Igor Matovič. His anti-corruption, anti-party, and anti-establishment appeal combined with an aggressive and confrontational but unconventional style of communication easily gained media attention. As it turned out, the success of OĽaNO was not just an episodic exception. It foreshadowed not only the emergence of new anti-establishment protest parties (Hanley and Sikk 2016) but also new issues structuring the party system, which proved important in the 2016 and 2020 parliamentary elections.

The party system and the election competition thus gained new dynamics in 2016 (Rybář and Spáč 2017). In 2016, the new political parties in parliament were all dominated by their leaders and this brought about new cultural issues and anti-establishment style of politics: the Slovak National Party (SNS) emphasized national populism and a strong state; Network (Sieť) new state management; We Are Family (SR) populism and cultural conservatism; and People's Party Our Slovakia (ĽSNS) represented the neo-fascist extreme right.

This shift was based on two key moments. The first was the migration crisis. Although Slovakia was not directly affected, migration evoked negative emotions and fears of most citizens. The Smer-SD tried to take advantage of the crisis before the elections and put this issue at the forefront of its campaign. This has only helped the new radical and extremist parties with the mobilization of anti-migration appeals (Baboš and Malová 2017). The second reason was the ever-growing popularity of non-mainstream alternatives, promising a new, different politics. This was clearly rooted in the dissatisfaction with the way established parties govern, plagued by allegations of corruption and against the power of oligarchs in political parties and state institutions. The continuation of the Smer-SD-led government after the 2016 elections reinforced this dissatisfaction and it fully erupted after the assassination of investigative journalist Ján Kuciak (and his partner) in February 2018. This provoked not only mass protests that led to the resignation of Prime Minister Robert Fico. Subsequent investigation revealed links or even control of state institutions, including the police, by oligarchs, systematic corruption, and criminal

activity by people close to the governing parties. It is therefore not surprising that at the 2020 elections the role of Smer-SD, which was the only party of the former coalition to get into parliament, significantly weakened. As at all previous elections, voters punished the government parties (Roberts 2008). This however does not seem to affect the parties' ambition to participate in government. Igor Matovič and his OĽaNO movement became a clear, albeit surprising, winner of the election. With a clever campaign, he managed to grasp the key issue of corruption (Bútorová 2020) and multiply his support during the last few weeks before the elections. The new centrist party of former President Andrej Kiska, For People (ZL), also entered parliament but this party eventually and gradually split.

In addition to changes in the party system, the organizational features of the parties are also important for coalition governance. With a few exceptions (KDH, SNS), all parliamentary parties in Slovakia after 2008 emerged as projects founded by their leaders either by fragmentations and divisions of parliamentary parties or as projects of political entrepreneurs seeking to gain political influence. This development can be attributed to the proportional electoral system with a single national district, which contributes to the importance of leaders and the personalization of politics.

As a result, the influence of ordinary members on party decision-making is marginal. Key decisions such as joining a governing coalition are under the control of the leader himself, or the top leadership of the party (Dolný and Malová 2016). The rise of new parties, especially after 2016, shows that established organizational structures and stable membership base are not necessary for electoral success.

Electoral alliances and pre-electoral coalitions

The formation of electoral alliances and pre-electoral coalitions is not common in Slovakia (see Table 11.1c), probably due to a higher parliamentary threshold for coalitions. The threshold increases for coalitions of parties – a coalition of two and three parties needs to get 7 per cent of the vote, a coalition of more than three parties 10 per cent. Actually, before our observation period, it happened that the overall election results for large pre-electoral alliances were lower than the sum of the electoral preferences for the individual parties (Szomolányi and Karvai 2019).

Table 11.1c Electoral alliances and pre-electoral coalitions in Slovakia, 2006–2021

<i>Election date</i>	<i>Constituent parties</i>	<i>Type</i>	<i>Types of pre-electoral commitment</i>
2020-02-29	SaS, ZL, KDH, PS-Spolu	PEC	Written contract

Notes:

Type: electoral alliance (EA) and/or pre-electoral coalition (PEC).

Types of pre-electoral commitments: written contract, joint press conference, separate declarations, and/or other.

Before the 2020 elections, however, opposition parties in face of the still dominant Smer-SD tried to create pre-election cooperation called the ‘Non-Aggression Pact’ to show voters their ability to work and prospectively govern together. The process was not smooth: the first agreement was signed by only two non-parliamentary opposition parties. SaS and ZL joined later, after fulfilling the requirements, namely accepting mutual ‘non-aggression’ in the election campaign, excluding any post-election cooperation with the Smer-SD, SNS, and ĽSNS, and a commitment to negotiate after the elections. Overall, however, the signing of the agreement proved counterproductive. During the long process of its preparation, the disagreements between the parties became wide open, in addition the voters of the conservative KDH perceived this cooperation with the liberal parties as a betrayal of the party’s principles (Bútorová 2020: 45). This eventually led to the party’s (KDH) failure in the election. The agreement had no impact on the post-election coalition negotiations either, as two of the four parties did not gain any seats in parliament and SaS and ZL represent only a minority in the government after the 2020 elections. Instead the election brought about the success of the opposition parties that did not participate in preparatory agreement.

Government formation

The bargaining process

As Table 11.2 shows, coalition negotiations are short, never longer than one month. In the case of ideologically close right-wing parties in 2010, it was no surprise that the bargaining process took a bit of time. First, the president formally appointed the chairman of the strongest parliamentary party, Smer-SD, to form a government, none of the right-wing parties that won a majority in the election agreed to negotiate with Smer-SD party leader Fico. As their strong motivation was to replace Smer-SD, eventually the right-wing parties were then able to agree despite some controversies, mainly on cultural issues.

The situation after the 2016 elections was significantly different. Due to the success of the far-right ĽSNS, none of the blocs alternating in the previous few periods in the government could master a majority. Complicated coalition negotiations or even early elections were expected (Rybář and Spáč 2017) but in the end party rules proved decisive (Strøm et al 1994). All parliamentary parties had resolutely ruled out cooperation with ĽSNS. The right-wing SaS and OĽaNO parties based their successful election campaign on a commitment not to join a coalition with Smer-SD. A new party – SR – declared it would not join any government but did not rule out its backing of a government without Smer-SD (Baboš and Malová 2017). The situation was quickly resolved when SNS, which became pivotal party, accepted the invitation of Smer-SD to start coalition negotiations (Rybář and Spáč 2017). The day after, the leaders of MH and Sieť also joined in. Despite the ideological heterogeneity of these parties, the coalition in 2016 (Fico III) was a quickly agreed government.

Table 11.2 Government formation period in Slovakia, 2006–2021

<i>Cabinet</i>	<i>Year in</i>	<i>Number of inconclusive bargaining rounds</i>	<i>Parties involved in the previous bargaining rounds</i>	<i>Bargaining duration of individual formation attempt (in days)</i>	<i>Number of days required in government formation</i>	<i>Total bargaining duration</i>	<i>Result of investiture vote (senate result in parentheses)</i>		
							<i>Pro</i>	<i>Abstention</i>	<i>Contra</i>
Fico I	2006	1	Smer-SD, SNS, ĽS-HZDS SDKU-DS, SMK, KDH, ĽS-HZDS	12 11	17	12	80	0	55
Radičová	2010	1	SDKU-DS, SaS, KDH, MH Smer-SD	20 1	27	22	79	0	66
Fico II	2012	0	Smer-SD	1	176	1	83	0	67
Fico III	2016	0	Smer-SD, SNS, MH, Siet'	10	17	13	79	2	61
Fico IV	2016	0	Smer-SD, SNS, MH	1	1	1			
Pellegrini	2018	0	Smer-SD, SNS, MH	6	7	6	81	2	61
Matovič	2020	0	OĽaNO, SR, SaS, ZL	18	21	18	93	0	48
Heger	2021	0	OĽaNO, SR, SaS, ZL	0	0	0	89	6	55

Apparently neither the deputies nor the members of the central bodies of MH and Siet were informed about this fundamental turnaround. As a result, some members and deputies left these parties in protest.³ According to one of the ministers who took part in the coalition negotiations, a welcoming approach prevailed by Smer-SD and accepting the programme and personnel demands of the partners led to a quick agreement.

As mentioned above, this government had a fast end in 2018. After the resignation of Prime Minister Fico, the same coalition aimed to proceed and the Vice-President of Smer-SD Peter Pellegrini delivered to the president the signatures of 79 deputies who guaranteed support for the new government. The president was able to use his powers and influenced the composition of the new cabinet however. He requested the nomination of ministers for the new government before the authorization to form a government was granted and made its granting conditional on the replacement of the proposed candidate of the Minister of the Interior (as a sensitive post responsible for investigating the murder of a journalist) which was achieved. The process of changing the government took only a few days.

After the 2020 elections, coalition negotiations were again fast. OĽaNO was the largest party with 53 seats, and Smer-SD was pushed to opposition with 38 seats. Although several combinations of minimal-winning coalitions were possible, eventually a surplus majority government formed, including SaS, SR, and ZL. In this way, they could ensure constitutional changes, limit the blackmail potential of small parties, and be safe against defections from parliamentary groups of government parties. Despite their heterogeneity both in economic and cultural issues, they were united by a markedly negative attitude towards Smer-SD and the will to cleanse the government of systematic corruption and connection with the oligarchs. Coalition negotiations in 2020 were swift, even though three of the four parties have no experience with participating in government. As in 2016, the parties focused primarily on office distribution and their programme priorities and did not agree on individual policy areas. The pressure for a quick agreement was intensified by the pandemic, which required government decision-making with clear parliamentary support.

The formation of Eduard Heger's government after the resignation of Prime Minister Matovič in 2021 was similar to the case of Peter Pellegrini's government in 2018. The party composition and distribution of posts did not change in any way. The only change was the swap of the posts of Prime Minister and Minister of Finance, which aimed to change the way of government management introduced by Prime Minister Matovič and at the same time still guarantee him as the leader of the winning party influence in the government by holding a key ministry.

The composition and size of cabinets

The number and structure of ministries stabilized after 2010 and did not change until 2020 (see [Table 11.3](#) for details). In addition to the prime minister and the ministers managing the ministries, the government during this

Table 11.3 Distribution of cabinet ministerships in Slovakian coalitions, 2006–2021

<i>Cabinet</i>	<i>Year in</i>	<i>Number of ministers per party (in descending order)</i>	<i>Total number of ministers</i>	<i>Number of watchdog junior ministers per party</i>	<i>Number of ministries</i>	<i>1. Prime minister</i>	<i>2. Finance</i>	<i>3. Foreign Affairs</i>	<i>4. Social Affairs</i>	<i>5. Interior</i>
Fico I	2006	11 Smer-SD, 3 SNS, 2 ĽS-HZDS	16	7 SNS, 5 Smer-SD, 3 ĽS-HZDS	15	Smer-SD	Smer-SD	Smer-SD	Smer-SD	Smer-SD
Radičová	2010	5 SDKU-DS, 4 SaS, 3 KDH, 3 MH	15	3 SaS, 3 SDKU-DS, 3 Ind., 2 MH, 1 KDH	13	SDKU-DS	SDKU-DS	SDKU-DS	SaS	KDH
Fico III	2016	9 Smer-SD, 3 SNS, 2 MH, 1 Siet'	15	13 Smer-SD, 5 MH, 5 SNS, 3 Siet'	14	Smer-SD	Smer-SD	Smer-SD	Smer-SD	Smer-SD
Fico IV	2016	9 Smer-SD, 3 SNS, 3 MH	15	14 Smer-SD, 5 MH, 5 SNS	14	Smer-SD	Smer-SD	Smer-SD	Smer-SD	Smer-SD
Pellegrini	2018	9 Smer-SD, 3 SNS, 3 MH	15	14 Smer-SD, 7 MH, 5 SNS	14	Smer-SD	Smer-SD	Smer-SD	Smer-SD	Smer-SD
Matovič	2020	8 OĽaNO, 3 SaS, 3 SR, 2 ZL	16	1 OĽaNO, 1 KDH, 1 SaS, 1 ZL	15	OĽaNO	OĽaNO	SaS	SR	OĽaNO
Heger	2021	8 OĽaNO, 3 SaS, 3 SR, 2 ZL	16	1 KDH, 1 ZL	15	OĽaNO	OĽaNO	SaS	SR	OĽaNO

period also included one Deputy Prime Minister without a permanent organizational structure. He managed a specially assigned agenda reflecting the importance of some policy for the government.

Although the parties try to avoid unpopular increases in the number of members of the government, the coalition agreed in 2020 to establish a new ministry by transforming the Deputy Prime Minister for Investments into a separate ministry that will address the long-standing problem of managing EU funds. This centralization of the management of EU funds may in the future also affect the attractiveness of some ministries in coalition bargaining. However, the number of cabinet members has increased as the post of Deputy Prime Minister without a permanent organizational structure was retained. The new agenda of legislative coordination was assigned to this post, which is important for fulfilling the priority of SR to start rapid and massive construction of rental housing.

The allocation of ministerial portfolios

The allocation of ministerial portfolios follows the share of parties' parliamentary mandates. The post of prime minister always belongs to the leader of the strongest coalition party. One of the few unwritten rules is that the Ministry of Finance – as the second most important position in the cabinet – would also belong to the largest coalition party. The importance of this post has not increased significantly during the economic crisis as the negative economic impact of the crisis was rather brief and moderated by high state budget deficits (Malová and Dolný 2016).

Other portfolios are allocated by the policy priorities of the parties, the professional orientation of the party's top members, and the intention to maintain 'balance' according to the perception of the ministries' importance. As confirmed by interviews, a certain hierarchy of ministries is acknowledged. The power ministries (defence, interior), the economic ministries (finance, economy, social affairs), and the ministries controlling large investments from EU funds (transport, agriculture) are regarded as the most important. Less preferred ministerial portfolios relate to education, health, justice, which tend to require politically sensitive reforms. The Ministries of Culture, Foreign Affairs, and the Environment are considered to be the least attractive. In the case of all coalition negotiations since 2010, the redistribution of posts was relatively smooth and the priorities of all parties were respected. It is interesting that since 2012, the Minister of Foreign Affairs has always been a respected diplomat without party affiliation.

Coalition agreements

With the exception of the governments in the early 1990s, all Slovak coalition cabinets have been based on a written coalition agreement. These have described the decision-making procedures and mechanisms for conflict

Table 11.4 Size and content of coalition agreements in Slovakia, 2006–2021

<i>Coalition</i>	<i>Year in</i>	<i>Size</i>	<i>General rules (in %)</i>	<i>Policy-specific procedural rules (in %)</i>	<i>Distribution of offices (in %)</i>	<i>Distribution of competences (in %)</i>	<i>Policies (in %)</i>
Fico I	2006	1475	20	0	35	0	45
Radičová	2010	7458	6	0	6	0	78
Fico III	2016	2908	42	1	16	1	27
Fico IV	2016	2908	42	1	16	1	27
		3813	50	1	14	0	21
Pellegrini	2018	3813	50	1	14	0	21
Matovič	2020	2830	30	14	11	6	25
Heger	2021	2830	30	14	11	6	25

resolutions, the allocation of posts both in the cabinet and parliament, and an outline of policy priorities. These coalition agreements, signed by the leaders of the parties, are the only binding documents that regulate the coalition parties' relations. Differences in their size (see [Table 11.4](#)) are primarily due to the scope of the policy priorities. At one extreme, the coalition agreement of the Radičová government in 2010 largely consists of programme priorities. The coalition agreements after 2016 are shorter and very similar in scope, structure, and content. They largely focus on the general rules that regulate the way the coalition works, and far less space is devoted to policies. This indicated that the mechanisms of cooperation and distribution of offices are the most important for parties. The speed of coalition negotiation both in 2016 and 2020 might also explain the lack of detailed policy proposals. Moreover, in 2020, the coalition agreement contains programme objectives, separately for each party. Yet, the parties and the public do not seem to attribute high importance to policy components of the coalition agreements. Policies are instead prominent in the government's programme statement, which the government must submit to parliament before the first vote of confidence. Coalition agreements in Slovakia usually do not contain agreements on specific procedural rules and distribution of competencies – with the exception of the 2020 coalition agreement. This agreement devotes 14 per cent of its content to procedural rules and distribution, the reason being that the competencies of the newly established Ministry of Investment and Informatization are outlined here.

In 2020, the process of signing the coalition agreement also changed, namely that in a ceremonial act all government MPs (and not only the party leaders) signed the document. This was an expression of the concerns about the coherence and unity of the coalition parliamentary groups and an attempt to implement moral pressure on MPs to support the government even if they leave the party.

Interestingly, in the 2016–2020 election period, the coalition agreement was signed up to three times. The first agreement was signed after the

elections and re-signing was necessary after only a few months when Sief disintegrated but apart from the relocation of its posts the content of the agreement did not change. The third agreement occurred in 2017, when the chairman of the SNS unexpectedly terminated the coalition agreement and demanded new settings for relations in the coalition. The reason was that the prime minister pressed to replace the Minister of Education after the scandal concerning the distribution of EU funds in the ministry, which the SNS chairman considered an interference in the party's decision-making autonomy. The minister resigned and eventually new coalition cooperation bodies (regional coalition councils, meetings of parliamentary club presidents) were set up and the share of general rules increased. However, the new bodies did not have any influence on the coalition governance. The resignations of Robert Fico in 2018 and Igor Matovič in 2021 did not impact on or alter the coalition agreements.

Coalition governance

The role of individual ministers in policy-making

The key powers of the Prime Minister in Slovakia are determined by the Constitution, providing him control over the composition of the cabinet by proposing appointments and removals of its members to the president. As mentioned before, it is not univocal whether the president is always obliged to respect the prime minister's proposals, but throughout the period under review, the president did not reject the formal proposals of the prime minister to appoint or remove a member of the government. Still, the need to form coalition governments in fact limits the prime minister's ability to determine the composition of the cabinet. Generally, the prime ministers respected the nominations of the coalition partners for the positions that belonged to them under the coalition agreement – with some exceptions. On one occasion – as has already been mentioned – in 2017, Prime Minister Fico openly pushed the SNS to replace its nominee. Then in 2009 Fico openly violated the coalition agreement and 'withdrew' from the SNS the Ministry of the Environment and replaced their minister with a member of his own party due to multiple corruption scandal allegations. At other occasions, the rule on the exclusive decision of a party on its nominees significantly restricts the prime minister's ability to shape his cabinet. This was evident in the government of Igor Matovič, when after disputes with the Minister of Economy (who was also the chairman of SaS) over the pandemic in December 2020, he described him as an idiot in an emotional radio interview and called for his resignation. Nevertheless, he did not propose the removal of the Minister to the president and respected the rules set out in the coalition agreement.

The model of the autonomous position of ministers in their ministries prevailed in all election periods until 2020. As confirmed by interviews with

members of the government, the prime minister did not intervene in their decisions, did not initiate issues to solve, nor did he give them direct tasks. His main function apparently was to coordinate, ensure the smooth negotiation of the government, and address priority issues. Consensual decision-making was the rule and voting took place only exceptionally. Such a setting of the cabinet model did not change even during the single-party majority government of Smer. In 2018, Prime Minister Fico initiated so-called control days in all ministries with the intention to evaluate the implementation of the government manifesto with individual ministers and set priorities for the next period. However, as one of the members of the government revealed in the interview, this control of the ministers by the prime minister served only as a presentation to the public and did not influence decisions of the ministers.

In the period of Igor Matovič's cabinet, the government's agenda and its decision-making have been fundamentally affected by the pandemic. The need for crisis management required the coordination of decision-making, which strengthened the position of the prime minister. The prime minister has *de facto* taken the lead in resolving the crisis and has been heavily involved in the measures taken. As part of this, he bypassed established institutional decision-making processes, politicized expertise to gain legitimacy in response to public reactions (Bušíková and Baboš 2020). In a number of cases, the government did not decide on fundamental measures by consensus, but by a majority decision. The deteriorating situation during the second wave of the pandemic, chaotic decision-making processes together with frequent changes in measures led to growing controversies between the prime minister and other parties in the coalition eventually led to a government crisis and the prime minister's resignation. The situation calmed down for a while after the nomination of the new Prime Minister Heger, but his success is limited by his loyalty to the party chairman Matovič. Moreover, Matovič in his new position as Minister of Finance continues to promote his own controversial proposals, emotional communication, and harsh criticism of the coalition partners, especially the chairman of SaS to whom he attributes responsibility for failures in the fight against the pandemic.

In general, we can observe an inclination towards Ministerial Government Model based on the division of power between the individual parties and their ministers. The pandemic, together with the personality and populist decision-making style of Prime Minister Matovič, significantly affected the decision-making of the cabinet and highlighted the role of the prime minister in line with Dominant Prime Minister Model. The change of the prime minister in 2021 did not eliminate tensions and disputes in the coalition, which complicates coalition governance, especially in times of crisis.

Coalition governance in the executive arena

Junior ministers (called state secretaries) serve as deputy ministers and can also replace ministers at the cabinet meetings although with only an advisory vote.

Each ministry usually has two junior ministers proposed by a minister and appointed by the government. The Minister also determines the part of the ministry's agenda for which the junior minister is responsible. Before 2010, junior ministers were representatives of a coalition party other than that of the minister (see Table 11.3). This method of mutual control of cabinet members by coalition parties was abandoned in Radičová cabinet in 2010 (Szomolányi and Karvai 2019: 464). After the 2016 elections, the governing coalition apparently returned to the model of cross-control and the distribution was even agreed in the coalition agreement. Nevertheless, the abilities of junior ministers to control the ministers were limited in practice and largely dependent on the minister's assignment of any agenda to the junior minister. This caused controversies between coalition parties.⁴

Following the 2020 elections, the new coalition introduced the model of full control and responsibility of the party for its ministry, implying that the nominations of junior ministers are fully within the competence of the ministers and their parties. The obligation to respect the Minister's proposal for these positions is also stated in the coalition agreement.⁵ Nevertheless, two junior ministerial posts were also won by representatives of another party from which the minister came. They did not have the role of a watchdog, but the intention was to implement their professional expertise at the ministry. This model quickly proved to be dysfunctional when junior ministers found that they had no influence on decision-making in these departments and resigned from their posts. Developments in this area of coalition cooperation also point to the gradual implementation of the Ministerial Government Model, which recognizes the autonomy of ministers and political parties within their ministry.

At the executive level, no specific institutions have been established in Slovakia that would have an impact on coalition governance (such as the inner cabinet). If necessary, the issues are resolved by the relevant minister among themselves on an ad hoc basis, or the dispute is submitted to the coalition council.

Governance mechanisms in the parliamentary arena

The basic mechanisms of governance in parliament were explicitly regulated in the coalition agreement in all periods and in similar ways. The chairmen of the parliamentary groups play a key role in the process of coordination and securing the support of coalition MPs for government proposals. For amending government proposals by coalition members in parliament, coalition agreements require the approval of the chairmen of all coalition parliamentary party groups and the consent of the member of the government who submitted the proposal. If some coalition MPs raise objections on the proposed legislation which they are unable to reconcile with the minister, the chairmen of the parliamentary groups will exclude it from the parliamentary session and it is submitted to the coalition council.

Coalition agreements also contain provisions prohibiting joint action with the opposition parties. The 2020 coalition agreement stipulates that opposition proposals can only be supported after their approval by the coalition council. Both 2016 and 2020 coalition agreements oblige the coalition not to initiate a vote of no confidence or participate in such votes. These mechanisms have a clear goal to ensure smooth support for not only government proposals in parliament but also full control of the government and government parties over the final form of the adopted legislation. At the same time, it marginalizes the opposition in the legislative process. The procedures introduced by the coalition agreements were also confirmed by the interviews. The government proposals did not have automatic support in parliament and the concerns of the MPs were resolved through the chairmen of the parliamentary groups. If the minister could not find support even after these negotiations, the coalition council discussed the proposal although this was a rare occasion.

Governance mechanisms with different types of actors (mixed)

The most important decision-making body of each Slovak coalition remains the coalition council, as before (see Szomolányi and Karvai 2019: 455). The Coalition Council usually consists of leaders and top representatives of the coalition parties (usually three to four members per coalition party). Its members are the chairmen of the parties, vice-chairmen, and some ministers or other officials, depending on the agenda under discussion. It meets regularly and relatively often (once every one or two weeks), or it can be convened at any time by one of the coalition parties. As [Table 11.5](#) shows, the coalition council is the primary (and currently the only) mechanism for resolving coalition conflicts. The negotiations are not public. Coalition agreements presuppose a consensual decision-making by the coalition council, which is usually the case. In addition, the 2020 coalition agreement provides for an explicit right of veto for each party on any issue. If a party does not exercise the veto option, majority decision-making is also possible. Coalition council meetings are usually held a few days before government meetings, so they serve not only as a mechanism for conflict resolution between coalition parties but also as a platform for leaders to reach an agreement before the government's decisions. Interviews have confirmed that the coalition council is a key body where decisions are actually made, either in case of conflict between coalition parties or to coordinate cooperation in government and parliament.

The coalition agreement in 2016 also allowed for a meeting of the 'expanded' coalition council, where two additional representatives of each party can be invited aimed to include the chairmen of the parliamentary groups.⁶ In addition to the coalition council, informal ad hoc meetings of coalition party chairmen also appeared during this period, but the final decisions were always taken by the coalition council.

Table 11.5 Coalition governance mechanisms in Slovakia, 1992–2021

Coalition	Year in	Coalition agreement	Agreement public	Election rule	Conflict management mechanisms			Personal union	Issues excluded from agenda	Coalition discipline in legislation/ other parl. behaviour	Freedom of appointment	Policy agreement	Junior ministers	Non- cabinet positions
					All used	Most common	For most serious conflicts							
Fico I	2006	POST	Yes	No	CoC, PS	CoC	CoC	No (SNS, LS-HZDS)	No	No/No	No	Varied	No	Yes
Radičová	2010	POST	Yes	No	CoC	CoC	CoC	No (MH, SaS)	No	All/All	Yes	Comp.	Yes	Yes
Fico III	2016	POST	Yes	No	CoC, PS	CoC	CoC	No (SNS, MH, Siet)	No	All/All	Yes	Comp.	Yes	Yes
Fico IV	2016	IE	Yes	No	CoC, PS	CoC	CoC	No (SNS, MH)	No	All/All	Yes	Comp.	Yes	Yes
Pellegrini	2018	IE	Yes	No	CoC, PS	CoC	CoC	No (Smer-SD, SNS, MH)	No	All/All	Yes	Comp.	Yes	Yes
Matovič	2020	POST	Yes	No	CoC	CoC	CoC	No (SR, ZL)	No	Most/All	Yes	Comp.	Yes	Yes
Heger	2021	IE	Yes	No	CoC	CoC	CoC	No (SR)	No	Most/All	Yes	Comp.	Yes	Yes

Notes:

During periods where the values for the variables remain identical, the first and last applicable cabinets are listed. The last applicable cabinet is right-justified in the coalition column.

Coalition agreement: IE = inter-election; POST = post-election.

Conflict management mechanisms: CaC = cabinet committee; CoC = coalition committee; PS = party summit.

Coalition discipline: all = discipline always expected; most = discipline expected except on explicitly exempted matters, no = discipline not expected.

Policy agreement: varied = policy agreement on a non-comprehensive variety of policies; comp. = comprehensive policy agreement; no = no explicit agreement.

Cabinet duration and termination

As Table 11.6 shows, with one exception, all the coalition cabinets ended prematurely after 2008 (Müller and Strøm 2008: 12; Strøm et al 2008: 139). The reasons for their termination were different and the change in the cabinet did not necessarily mean a change in the party composition or the patterns of coalition governance.

Table 11.6 Cabinet termination in Slovakia, 2006–2021

<i>Cabinet</i>	<i>Relative duration of cabinet (%)</i>	<i>Mechanisms of cabinet termination</i>	<i>Terminal Parties</i>	<i>Policy area(s)</i>	<i>Comments</i>
Fico I Radičová	99.7 32	1 4, 6, 7a	SaS, SDKU-DS, MH, KDH		The government did not succeed in vote of no confidence, since the vote was held together with the vote on EFSF, and SaS abstained on the vote, thus the government did not gain the confidence of the parliament
Fico II Fico III	99.7	1 8	Sieť		Disintegration of the ‘Sieť’, change to a three-party coalition
Fico IV		7b	11	Smer-SD, MH	Mass protests and the political crisis after the murder of investigative journalist J. Kuciak with demands for resignation of PM Fico and Ministry of Interior. These demands are supported by MH. The coalition continued with a new prime minister and a reconstructed government
Pellegrini Matovič		1 7a	OĽaNO, SaS, ZL		Resigned after his handling of the Covid-19 pandemic. Matovič bought Russia’s coronavirus vaccine without consulting his coalition partners in government

Notes:

Technical terminations

1: Regular parliamentary election; 2: other constitutional reason; 3: death of prime minister.

Discretionary terminations

4: Early parliamentary election; 5: voluntary enlargement of coalition; 6: cabinet defeated by opposition in parliament; 7a/b: conflict between coalition parties: (a) policy and/or (b) personnel; 8: intra-party conflict in coalition party or parties; 9: other voluntary reason.

Terminal events

10: Elections, non-parliamentary; 11: popular opinion shocks; 12: international or national security event; 13: economic event; 14: personal event.

The termination of cabinets

The fall of the right-wing government of Iveta Radičová in 2012 was caused by a conflict between the coalition partners over the ratification of the European Financial Stability Facility extension (Szomolányi and Karvai 2019: 468). The conflict stemmed from the frustration of SaS, which as a new party was not able to enforce several priorities of its programme in the coalition. Although the proposal had the support of the opposition Smer-SD, it refused to help the government with its vote. Prime Minister Radičová decided to combine the vote on the proposal with the vote of confidence in the government, assuming that SaS will not risk the fall of the government. However, SaS decided to stick to a 'principled' position and did not support the pact. It was approved two days later after the three coalition parties agreed with Smer-SD on early elections. Even if the fall of the government was related to the financial crisis, this issue was instrumentally useful for the short-term domestic political goals of two parties (Szomolányi and Karvai 2019: 468) and it showed the political inexperience of the SaS, which sacrificed the government in favour of making its principles visible on an unimportant technical issue.

Robert Fico's cabinet formed after the elections in March 2016 (Fico III) lasted unchanged for only 160 days. The reason was a change in party composition, which was related to the disintegration of the smallest coalition party Siet'. The second change of cabinet in this term was much more dramatic and was caused by the popular opinion shock triggered by the assassination of investigative journalist Ján Kuciak in February 2018. Tensions and massive protests across the country were fuelled by revelations that the police did not act to protect the victim and that the prime minister's close associates were connected with a representative of the Italian mafia. Prime Minister Fico underestimated the seriousness of the situation, as his communication and reluctance to dismiss the Minister of the Interior only increased public anger and pressure for his own resignation. This development also became unacceptable for the MH, which decided to demand early elections also promoted by President Kiska. However, coalition crisis was finally resolved by Prime Minister Fico's decision to resign with the agreement of the coalition parties to create a cabinet under the leadership of Smer-SD Vice-President Peter Pellegrini. The parties thus opted for a pragmatic compromise that avoided the government crisis or early elections in a tense situation that would not be beneficial to either of them.

Igor Matovič's 2020 government lasted only about one year in office, when he resigned under pressure in March 2021 as a direct consequence of the pandemic crisis. The immediate reason for the government crisis was the prime minister's negotiated purchase of the Russian Sputnik V vaccine, which was supposed to solve the slow vaccination caused by the lack of vaccines. The secret purchase of vaccines in Russia as well as widespread antigen testing was the prime minister's ideas and he implemented them secretly without consulting the coalition partners. The two smaller coalition parties, SaS and ZL, could no longer accept the prime minister's way of making decisions and demanded

his resignation together with the Minister of Health. Yet, it was only after the resignation of five members of the government and the realization that he could not maintain a majority in parliament that the Prime Minister reluctantly stepped down with an agreement on a new government where he exchanged posts with the Minister of Finance.

Conclusion

The study of coalition governance in Slovakia after 2008 shows important changes in the patterns of formation of government coalitions, but at the same, time there was a certain settlement of rules of coalition governance corresponding to the Ministerial Government Model. New developments in the formation of coalition governments are largely due to changes in the party system. The growth of new parties emphasizing a new type of policy with anti-corruption and anti-establishment rhetoric after 2012 ended the pattern of alternating right and left governments based more on fairly coherent socioeconomic policies (Szomolányi and Karvai 2019: 471). The events of the assassination of investigative journalist Ján Kuciak and his partner and the subsequent political, public, and media pressure led not only to the first voluntary resignation of a prime minister since 1993 (Láštic 2019) but also to the dominance of corruption rule of law issues before the 2020 elections. Therefore, the question arises if and when the traditional L/R dimension again can still best capture the party competition in Slovakia, in a way that has been common in the CEE context, as argued by Bergman et al (2019). The emphasis on issues of corruption together with the entry of the extreme right into parliament without coalition potential implied the creation of less homogenous government coalitions. Still, the higher complexity of coalition negotiations has not impacted much on cabinet formation: government coalitions have always formed very quickly during this period. This indicates the priority of the office-seeking strategy of political parties in deciding to join the government, which is in line with the noted trend of neglecting policy programmes in coalition agreements. Complex policy programmes have with the new anti-establishment and populist parties been replaced by a small set of narrow programmatic preferences. This not only reduces the need for developed mutual control mechanisms (Falcó-Gimeno 2014) but also facilitates the parties' agreement in coalition negotiations. The smooth and fast coalition formations are also helped by the organizational character of the parties, namely leaders (founders) dominance without developed organizational structures. Thus, they are not constrained by the need to find compromises within their own party, as often is the case in negotiation processes in Western Europe (Diermeier and van Roozendaal 1998: 610).

The coalition governance was characterized by the stabilization of its rules and the strengthening of features Ministerial Government Model based on the division of power between individual parties and their ministers (Laver and Shepsle 1994, 1996). Ministers thus have control over government policies

in their areas, and coalition agreements also give them important opportunities to control legislation in parliament. During this period, ministerial power was further strengthened by the abandonment of the watchdog function of junior ministers by coalition partners. The autonomy of ministers is thus limited mainly by their own political party. As no permanent mechanisms for coalition control of cabinet members are established in coalition agreements, their control is limited to ad hoc objections to their proposals from coalition parties or members of parliament, which are resolved in the coalition council.

Since 2008, we have seen a trend of stabilization of patterns of coalition cooperation and governance in line with this model, and neither the economic crisis nor the migration crisis has practically affected them. However, we cannot say that these events have had no impact on Slovak politics. The government fell in 2012 related to the economic crisis, and the migration crisis was one of the topics of the election campaign in 2016 contributing to the importance of cultural issues and strengthening extremist and populist parties. In both cases, however, the impact of the two crises was relatively limited and did not have a fundamental influence on the patterns of coalition governance. In the case of the financial crisis, the economic downturn was only temporary, and thanks to the relatively low public debt, governments did not have to resort to significant cuts in government spending and absorbed the increased costs by increasing the deficit. The fall of the government in 2012 was rather a consequence of using this issue for short-term party goals. The migration crisis did not directly affect Slovakia at all, as it was not a destination or a transit corridor. The topic of migration did not even become a significant issue in the party competition, as we could not find any relevant party that would be open to accept migrants or refugees from the Middle East and Africa, or to change restrictive asylum policies.

In contrast, the Corona pandemic, which hit Slovakia just after the change of government, significantly disrupted the relatively stabilized patterns of coalition government and parliamentary democracy. Even though the crisis caught Slovakia organizationally and materially unprepared and it was not possible to use standard decision-making processes, the efforts of new Prime Minister Matovič to personally and innovatively manage the crisis disrupted some established rules of coalition governance. This approach, complemented by a new style of 'online' communication and a tendency to escalate conflicts with his opponents, caused rapidly deteriorating relations between coalition partners. This shows that populist leaders with unorthodox approaches, which do not fully respect established rules, do not only complicate coalition governance but in the extraordinary context even a shift towards the Dominant Prime Minister Model could also be observed.

Despite the disturbed relations and the complicated cooperation of the coalition parties, they were able to agree on a clear rejection of Russian aggression and aid to Ukraine (including military). So far, these events have not affected the coalition government in Slovakia. In contrast to the migration

crisis, Slovakia also adopted a welcoming approach to the wave of Ukrainian refugees who hit the country.

It is not easy to directly connect the way of coalition governance with the trends of quality of democracy in Slovakia, where we did not notice significant changes. In this period, Slovakia does not record significant illiberal tendencies, not even during the period of the majority one-party Smer-SD government in the period 2012–2016. There can be more explanations – negative authoritarian experiences from the period of Vladimír Mečiar’s rule, relatively developed civil society and independent media, lack of ideological motivations (see, e.g., Bakke and Sitter 2022). On the other hand, Slovakia has been struggling for a long time with insufficient functioning of the rule of law and systematic corruption. To some extent, the dominance of Smer-SD as a dominant force in governments for most of the period under review contributed to this. In addition to a popular programme combining social security with moderate conservatism, the party also brought an understanding of government and state institutions as resources and opportunities for systematic enrichment and influence for an interconnected network of top party officials and oligarchs.

Greater autonomy of ministers with little control from other parties in the coalition government since 2016 has enabled the continuation and further development of networks of ties between business and state officials. As the investigation after the murder of a journalist gradually showed, these structures were completely controlled by key state institutions (police, courts, prosecutor’s office, top representatives of state agencies), which can be described as state capture (Innes 2014). But it is hard to prove that the rules of coalition governance would be the cause of this situation or rather adapted to this approach.

Appendix: *List of parties*

<i>Parties</i>	
KSS	Communist Party of Slovakia (Komunistická Strana Slovenska)
ZRS	Association of Workers in Slovakia (Združenie Robotníkov Slovenska)
SDL	Democratic Left (Strana Demokratickej L’avice)
SV	Common Choice (Spoločná Voľba)
Smer-SD	Direction-Social Democracy (Smer-Sociálna Demokracia)
SOP	Party of Civic Understanding (Strana Občianskeho Porozumenia)
ŠNS	Slovak National Party (Slovenská Národná Strana)
ĽS-HZDS	People’s Party-Movement for Democratic Slovakia (Ľudová Strana-Hnutie za Demokratické Slovensko)
SMK	Hungarian Coalition Party (Strana Maďarskej Koalície)
DUS	Democratic Union of Slovakia (Demokratická Únia Slovenska)
MH	Bridge (MOST-HÍD)
KDH	Christian Democratic Movement (Kresťanskodemokratické Hnutie)
OĽaNO	Common People and Independent Personalities (Obyčajný ľudia a nezávislé osobnosti)
ANO	Alliance of the New Citizen (Aliancia Nového Občana)
SDK	Slovak Democratic Coalition (Slovenská Demokratická Koalícia)

SDKU-DS	Slovak Democratic and Christian Union-Democratic Party (Slovenská Demokratická a Kresťanská Únia-Demokratická strana)
SaS	Freedom and Solidarity (Sloboda a Solidarita)
ĽSNS	People's Party Our Slovakia (Ľudová strana Naše Slovensko)
Sieť	#Network (#Sieť)
SR	We Are Family (Sme rodina)
ZL	For People (Za ľudí)
HLAS-SD	Voice-Social Democracy (Hlas-sociálna demokracia)
Republika	Republic (Republika)
Z-NS	Life-National Party (Život-Národná strana)

Notes:

Party names are given in English, followed by the party name in Slovak in parentheses. If several parties have been coded under the same abbreviation (successor parties), or if the party has changed their names, these are listed in reverse chronological order followed by the period during which a specific party or name was in use.

Notes

- 1 The threshold increases for coalitions of parties – a coalition of two and three parties needs to get 7% of the vote, a coalition of more than three parties 10%.
- 2 Resolution of Constitutional Court 7/2021.
- 3 Sieť lost 3 members in parliament, MH 1, the government could rely on a majority of 83 MPs at the beginning of its term.
- 4 The chairman of the SNS, Andrej Danko, openly criticized the Ministry of Health, where, according to him, his junior minister ‘only made coffee’. A similar case was the junior minister by Smer-SD at the Ministry of Justice, to whom the Minister assigned a peripheral consumer protection agenda and completely cut her off from influence over the decision-making of the ministry.
- 5 With the exception of junior ministers in Ministry of Culture, which OLaNO leaves to the ZL party in a deal for the free voting of its members of parliament on ‘life protection’ (abortion) issues, not as watchdogs.
- 6 In September 2017, after a sudden coalition crisis caused by the chairman of the SNS, the government parties signed an amendment to the coalition agreement, which introduced new bodies of regional and district coalition councils but there is no evidence that they have ever been convened.

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